Blackwood If you have an agreed suit, you can find out how many Aces (and Kings) partner holds by using a 4NT bid. A reply of 5♣ shows 0 or 4, 5♦ shows 1, 5♥ shows 2 and 5♠ shows 3.

If your side has all four Aces, bidding 5NT will repeat the process for Kings.

The Replier can show one Ace plus a Void by bidding 6 of the Void suit if it ranks below the agreed trump, or 6 of the trump suit if the Void ranks above.
A Reply of 5NT shows two Aces plus a Void in some suit.

Gerber : Similar to Blackwood, this convention uses a 4♣ bid to initiate the Ace question, with 4♦ showing 0 or 4, 4♥ showing 1, 4♠ showing 2 and 4NT showing 3.

Not all 4♣ bids are Gerber, and deciding which ones are needs to be addressed by the partnership. For these Deals 4♣ is Gerber only when it follows a bid of 1NT or 2NT.

BakerBridge has complete lessons for these two conventions.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣10

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥5

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥9

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥4

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 9 8 6 4
♥ A K Q
♦ 7
♣ K J 6 3

♠ 10 2
♥ 5 4 2
♦ Q J 3 2
♣ A Q 5 2



♠ Q J
♥ 10 9 6 3
♦ K 10 9 4
♣ 10 9 8

♠ K 7 5 3
♥ J 8 7
♦ A 8 6 5
♣ 7 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♣10

NORTH may have a good hand but SOUTH merely gave a simple raise. Even if SOUTH has a maximum there won't be a slam.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A 10 9 4 2
♥ A 7
♦ 10 5 4
♣ 9 7 3

♠ Q 7 5 3
♥ 10 9 4 2
♦ A 8
♣ K J 4



♠ —
♥ K Q J 8 6 3
♦ K J 2
♣ A Q 6 5

♠ K J 8 6
♥ 5
♦ Q 9 7 6 3
♣ 10 8 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♥	Pass
3♥	Pass	4♣	Pass
4♦	Pass	6♥	
All Pass			

6♥ by East
Lead: ♥5

EAST has a tough decision after the two Control-showing bids.

If he uses Blackwood and WEST shows two Aces he will be no better off, because he won't know if one of the Aces is the useless ♠A. Based on knowing that WEST holds the ♦A, he bids 6♥, hoping that he can at least make that and that 7 isn't a laydown!

Board 3
South Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A 7 ♥ K 3 ♦ Q J 9 8 7 4 2 ♣ 7 6	
♠ 10 9 4 3 ♥ Q J 4 ♦ 10 ♣ Q J 10 9 3		♠ Q J 8 5 ♥ 8 7 6 5 2 ♦ 6 5 ♣ 5 2
	♠ K 6 2 ♥ A 10 9 ♦ A K 3 ♣ A K 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	4♣	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♣[2]	Pass	5NT[3]
Pass	7NT		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 0 or 4 aces
3. asks for kings

7NT by South
Lead: ♣Q

NORTH isn't sure just how much he can make, but surely 6♦ isn't too much to hope for.

He starts with a Gerber 4♣ and SOUTH shows three Aces.

Hmmm, 5♣ asks for Kings and SOUTH shows three.

Hmm, NORTH can now count all thirteen tricks, so he forgets about the ♦ slam and bids 7NT.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 6 5 3 ♥ 9 4 ♦ A 9 7 6 4 2 ♣ 4	
♠ A K Q ♥ K Q 6 ♦ K Q 3 ♣ J 8 7 5		♠ J 8 ♥ J 7 2 ♦ 8 5 ♣ A K Q 10 9 6
	♠ 9 7 4 2 ♥ A 10 8 5 3 ♦ J 10 ♣ 3 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2NT	Pass	4♣	Pass
4♥	Pass	4NT	
All Pass			

4NT by West
Lead: ♥9

EAST has 13 points and can contribute six tricks so she figures that twelve tricks will be a slam (dunk).

However, just to make sure the opponents don't take the first two tricks she checks with Gerber.

Uh Oh, missing two Aces she signs off at 4NT. She could also happily play 5♣, but it would be tricky to get there. Very tricky.

Board 5
North Deals
None Vul

♠ K 7 5
♥ Q 9 6
♦ A 9 8 3
♣ A Q 7

♠ J 10 8 2
♥ J 10 2
♦ Q 10 5
♣ J 8 2



♠ 9 4 3
♥ A 8 5 4
♦ J 7 4 2
♣ 9 4

♠ A Q 6
♥ K 7 3
♦ K 6
♣ K 10 6 5 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	4NT

All Pass

4NT by North
Lead: ♥4

Yes, this has nothing to do with Gerber or Blackwood, but everything to do with smart bidding.

SOUTH has a 16 points and NORTH has 15, 16 or 17. SOUTH wants to be in 6NT if NORTH has 17, but merely a Notrump game if she has 15 or 16.

The way to find out is to bid 4NT - not Blackwood but merely an invitation to bid 6NT. In this case, NORTH has but 15 points and declines the invitation. If her ♥Q were changed to the ♥A she would bid 6NT and collect her twelve easy tricks.